Whose Contribution Counts?

Generative AI, Cultural Participation and Collective Authorship in Research-Creation

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Summary

I am an artistic practitioner and researcher working through research-creation. Trained in architecture and landscape architecture, I build interactive 3D environments and multiplayer games and study them with participants. This project asks how generative artificial intelligence (GenAI), meaning the models, interfaces and platforms that operate them, reorganizes interpretive authority and collective authorship in collaborative artistic practice. Three subquestions follow: how selected tools, defaults and facilitation arrangements amplify, standardize, misread or pass over participants' culturally situated contributions; how collaborators negotiate uptake, refusal, credit and responsibility among themselves, the group, the artist-facilitator, models, platforms and institutions; and how artistic methods and a public artwork can make these usually hidden distributions perceptible, debatable and revisable. As platforms mediate more cultural production, they help decide whose meanings become legible and who answers for shared work. The design begins with my own studio inquiry, followed by consultation with four to six practitioners, workshops with 18–24 adult interdisciplinary artists in three cohorts with participant observation, semi-structured focus groups, and the co-creation of a room-scale collaborative installation proposed for exhibition at York University. It would contribute a communication-and-culture account of how GenAI redistributes interpretive authority, a research-creation method for studying it, and an artwork that keeps those negotiations visible.

1 The problem and its wider stakes

GenAI increasingly stands between people and the means of cultural production, through systems whose training data, defaults, moderation rules and ownership are set elsewhere, largely by platform companies (Crawford, 2021). I treat it not as a neutral tool or an autonomous artist but as part of a cultural infrastructure that also includes interfaces, access conditions, institutions and facilitators.

The study investigates three mechanisms through which this infrastructure acquires social stakes. The first is *platformized interpretive authority*. Richards (2025, 276) argues that the "safe and helpful" assistant functions "as a proxy for authority"; Caines (2026, 187–188, 194) found that subscription costs, privacy tiers and opacity shaped what she and her students could make; and Caines and Watson (2023, 267) describe a project

whose outcome lay "completely in the hands of the corporations that designed the software". The second is *cultural legibility, standardization and misrecognition*. South Asian participants found that text-to-image models reproduced an outsider's gaze on their cultures (Qadri et al., 2023), AI writing suggestions moved Indian writers toward Western styles (Agarwal et al., 2025), and stories written with model-generated ideas grew more alike collectively (Doshi and Hauser, 2024); these findings concern particular models and tasks. The third is *conflict among technical provenance, recognition, authorship, ownership, credit and responsibility*: a system can record who supplied what while collaborators credit someone else, and artists' work enters training data without their consent (Jiang et al., 2023). Environmental cost, labour displacement and misinformation are context (Caines, 2026, 182), not objects of this study.

Participation and authorship matter because they are where these mechanisms become practical. They show who can make meaning with these systems, whose contribution stays recognizable, who can refuse a model's reading, and who answers for the work once it circulates. A small qualitative study cannot measure GenAI's effect on society; situated research-creation can make these processes observable and yield concepts that transfer analytically, not statistically.

2 Practice, position and continuity

I come to this question as a practitioner. Architecture at Tabriz Islamic Art University and landscape architecture at Istanbul Technical University taught me to treat designed environments as media of social life, in which thresholds, paths and light shape who gathers and who is seen; in ITU's Virtual Landscape Lab I studied how people perceive mediated environments (Jahandideh et al., 2023). My master's research in Interactive Arts and Technology at Simon Fraser University, in Steve DiPaola's iViz Lab, asked what happens when a technical system translates an ambiguous human state into something others can perceive. In a three-player networked Unity game, I rendered each teammate's heart rate and heart-rate variability as one animated halo, designed on the premise that measurement constitutes rather than reports what it names, so that the cue offered a trace to interpret rather than an emotion label (Jahandideh et al., 2026). Teams supported a struggling teammate faster than with no cue, matching an explicit numeric display at lower workload and invasiveness, yet rated the numbers more trustworthy and useful, so ambiguity and precision traded off. Participants accepted the cue only when it was optional, mutable and subtle, and the paper argues for a right to be illegible. In *BioTerrarium*, a Unity world I built, the player's physiology shaped fog, vegetation and light rather than a meter, an approach I called ambient reciprocity (Jahandideh, 2026). Across both projects, representation was not neutral: it shaped what others could perceive, what they trusted, when they offered help and what control people demanded over their own visibility.

The doctorate carries that question from physiological signals to cultural production. When a model and platform turn a participant's words, images, sounds or gestures into collective material, whose interpretation becomes visible, whose contribution remains recognizable, who can revise or refuse the transformation, and who is credited or held responsible? Neither MA study examined GenAI, authorship or culture; they gave me skills in Unity and C#, multiplayer systems, live-data integration and ethics-approved mixed-methods re-

search. The PhD moves from evaluating systems to artistic inquiry, participant observation, focus groups and cultural analysis. As artist, developer, facilitator, observer, analyst and curator, I will shape what participants can do, so documenting my decisions is part of the method.

Artistic field

Four practices change specific decisions in the design. Anna Ridler's *Myriad (Tulips)* exhibits thousands of tulip photographs she labelled by hand, making a dataset's labour and classification into the artwork (Ridler, 2018); it leads me to keep prompts, labels and rejected outputs as exhibitable material. Stephanie Dinkins's *Not the Only One* is trained on oral histories from three generations of women in her family and hosted locally to protect community data (Dinkins, 2018); it makes data custody a criterion for choosing tools. Holly Herndon and Mat Dryhurst's *The Call* trained choral models on recordings of fifteen community choirs and tested a data trust (Herndon and Dryhurst, 2024); because its governance was designed by the artists and institution, my workshops instead ask participants to set credit and data rules. Sougwen Chung's *Drawing Operations* pairs her drawing with robotic systems trained on her own drawings and gestures (Chung, 2014), a model of improvised human–machine co-performance that my scores extend from one artist to many contributors. Caines's *multiPLAY*, with workshops, open studios and an artist hackathon for Canadian improvisers (Caines, 2019), and *ImprovEnabled*, a strengths-based improvisation project developed with community partners (Caines and Stewart, 2015), are methodological precedents for community-engaged improvised making, not settings for this study.

3 Research questions, argument and terms

Central question. How do GenAI systems reorganize interpretive authority and collective authorship in collaborative artistic practice?

SQ1. *Translation and cultural legibility.* How do selected models, interfaces, defaults, moderation systems and facilitation arrangements amplify, standardize, misread, refuse or pass over participants' culturally situated contributions? (Studio records; workshop episodes; prompts and outputs.)

SQ2. *Negotiation and governance.* How do collaborators negotiate uptake, revision, refusal, attribution, responsibility and decisions among contributors, the group, the artist-facilitator, models, platforms and institutions? (Episodes; group rules; focus groups.)

SQ3. *Research-creation and public form.* How can collaborative artistic methods and a public artwork make these usually hidden distributions of interpretive authority perceptible, debatable and revisable? (Scores; versions of the artwork; focus groups.)

Provisional argument. GenAI does not simply add a nonhuman collaborator to collective art-making; it may reorganize the conditions under which contributions become legible, transformable, creditable and contestable by redistributing interpretive authority among participants, facilitators, models, platforms and insti-

tutions. The research may confirm, complicate or reject this proposition, and treats refusal, silence, failure and non-use as meaningful outcomes.

Terms. *Participation* means taking part in decisions, not only access or interaction. *Recognition* (legibility) is whether others perceive a contribution as meaningful and as someone's. *Interpretive authority* is the capacity to decide what a contribution means and becomes. *Attribution* or *credit* is public acknowledgement; *authorship* is felt and negotiated responsibility for a work; *ownership* is a legal or contractual claim; *responsibility* is who answers for consequences; and *technical provenance* is a system's record of inputs. *Culturally situated contributions* are languages, references, idioms, memories, aesthetic conventions, performance practices or community knowledge that participants themselves identify. The study does not judge authenticity or treat anyone as representing a culture.

4 Theoretical framework

Participation as power. Jenkins and colleagues define a participatory culture as one in which "members believe their contributions matter, and feel some degree of social connection with one another" (Jenkins et al., 2006, 3). Carpentier (2016) asks whether participants share power at the moments when decisions are made, which separates participation from access and interaction, and Bishop (2012) cautions that participatory art is too often judged by ethical rather than artistic criteria.

Mediation and infrastructure. Suchman (2007) shows that agency is figured and attributed in situated practice rather than residing in humans or machines. AI-mediated communication research describes models that modify messages between people (Hancock et al., 2020), and the companies that run them present themselves as "platforms" while shaping the terms by which they are judged (Gillespie, 2010).

Collective production and recognition. Becker (1982) treats art as the work of a cooperative network organized by conventions that decide whose contribution counts as artistic. Hodson (2019, 32) shows that even when design is opened to others, "the story is still told in terms of design-led collaboration".

Research-creation and critical improvisation. Research-creation makes the making a way of knowing (Chapman and Sawchuk, 2012) and can challenge the norms of the fields it crosses (Loveless, 2019, 37, quoted in Caines and Watson, 2023, 255). Caines treats improvisation as a method built on "real-time decision-making with others, surprise, supported and accountable risk taking, deep listening, and … the reconfiguration of mistake" (Caines and Watson, 2023, 273; see also Caines, 2021), and reads her GenAI work as "a kind of critical improvisation practice" marked by "a constant cycle of navigating power, adaptation, surprise, failure, and creation" (Caines, 2026, 193). I ask how that cycle unfolds when the material is one another's offers.

5 Related work

Table 1 compares the closest studies and artworks. The gap is conceptual and methodological: following how contributions and authorship are negotiated across several GenAI modalities, sustained workshops, focus groups and a public artwork.

Table 1: Closest related studies and artworks, as reported in each source.

Work and context	AI role and opacity	Participation and decision power	Credit and data governance	What this project adds
Xu et al. (2026); student groups, one design task	One shared ChatGPT interface; proprietary	Groups negotiate AI output in decisions	Not the focus	Sustained art-making; credit across sessions
Qadri et al. (2023); South Asian communities	Commercial text-to-image models	Participants evaluate outputs as experts	Not the focus	Making with tools, not only evaluating them
Agarwal et al. (2025); Indian and US writers	LLM writing suggestions	Individual tasks in a controlled experiment	Not the focus	Collective work in a situated setting
Caines (2026); course design	Several web GenAI tools	Instructor chooses tools by cost and privacy	Privacy tiers weighed against cost	Participants negotiating one another's offers
Ridler (2018); artwork	Artist-made dataset	One artist	Labelling labour made visible	Collective, contested labour
Herndon and Dryhurst (2024); 15 UK choirs	Choral models trained on recordings	Choirs contribute; artists design	Data trust experiment	Rules negotiated by participants
Dinkins (2018); family oral histories	Locally hosted model	Family members as data sources	Community data kept local	Many contributors negotiating in workshops

6 Research-creation design

The project follows the program's research-creation option: a substantial creative work and a 150–200-page written dissertation that carries the theoretical argument (Joint Graduate Program in Communication & Culture, 2021). Its five phases overlap and feed back into one another (Figure 1).

Phase 1: Studio inquiry. Before recruiting anyone, I will spend a sustained period investigating collaboration and GenAI through my own practice, comparing a deliberately limited ecology of three or four tool families with non-AI processes. Criteria are artistic relevance, cost, data and privacy terms, documentability, user control and known cultural defaults. I will keep a reflexive studio journal, a decision log, an archive of failures and refusals, and a record of each tool's version and terms of service, and will produce a series of exploratory works and scores. The phase ends by selecting no more than two primary generative modalities for the workshops; Unity remains the environment for spatial assembly and exhibition. It is artistic inquiry, not a technology benchmark.

Phase 2: Consultation and pilots. Four to six adult interdisciplinary artists, improvisers, community-engaged practitioners or creative technologists will work as paid consultants. In pilot sessions they test and

critique draft scores and the accessibility, consent, refusal, attribution and data-governance protocols. They are not research participants or co-researchers; only the resulting protocol changes are recorded.

Phase 3: Collaborative workshops. Subject to feasibility, ethics, honoraria and supervisory advice, about 18–24 adults will take part in three cohorts of six to eight. The principal population is adult interdisciplinary artists and community-engaged creative practitioners, recruited by open calls in Toronto and York Region, excluding anyone I teach; discipline, GenAI experience, age and cultural and linguistic background are sought as variation, and the sample is not representative. These practitioners have working vocabularies for collaboration, attribution and situated expression, and adults can weigh public exhibition and contested data practices. The scale rests on information power (Malterud et al., 2016), not on statistical power or declared saturation (Braun and Clarke, 2021). Each cohort attends four workshops of about two and a half hours: agreeing conventions and making without assuming AI is needed; working with the two selected modalities and with AI/non-AI combinations; deciding collective rules for attribution, data, credit and decisions; reflecting on misreading, standardization, surprise and failure; and developing materials and scores for the installation. Anyone may accept, revise, reject, fork or withhold a transformation without losing creative standing. I will conduct disclosed participant observation, and field notes and the journal will record when I make art, facilitate, observe or analyze. With consent I will collect recordings, prompts and outputs, version histories, logs, artifacts and group rules; a log records system events, not intentions.

Phase 4: Focus groups. Each cohort then joins one semi-structured focus group of 60–90 minutes on recognition, authorship, cultural legibility, refusal, trust, responsibility, platform authority, data governance and desired changes. Focus groups make participants' interaction part of the data (Kitzinger, 1994), but confidentiality cannot be guaranteed within a group, which participants are told beforehand. Participants reflect on the work without sharing analytic authority, so this is not co-analysis; an individual follow-up is offered to anyone who prefers to speak privately.

Phase 5: Co-creation and public artwork. The provisional form is a room-scale, multichannel interactive installation assembled in Unity, in which contribution trajectories, transformations, revisions, refusals, absences, parallel versions and contested credit remain visible or audible rather than being erased by a polished output; its modalities will be narrowed in Phases 1 and 3. Making produces knowledge here in four ways: scores act as propositions that workshops test; failures expose infrastructural assumptions; revisions redistribute decision power; and the installation holds unresolved conflicts open to public encounter rather than illustrating written findings. Each cohort keeps an autonomous module with its own credit and data rules, only the shared spatial structure is negotiated across cohorts, and unresolved disagreements remain as parallel versions rather than being forced into consensus. The work is proposed for the first-floor Art Gallery at York's Markham Campus (York University Markham Campus, 2024) or another York or partner venue, subject to approval and resources; no venue is confirmed. Consent to exhibit is separate from consent to research, no audience data will be collected, and the work will be documented for examination.

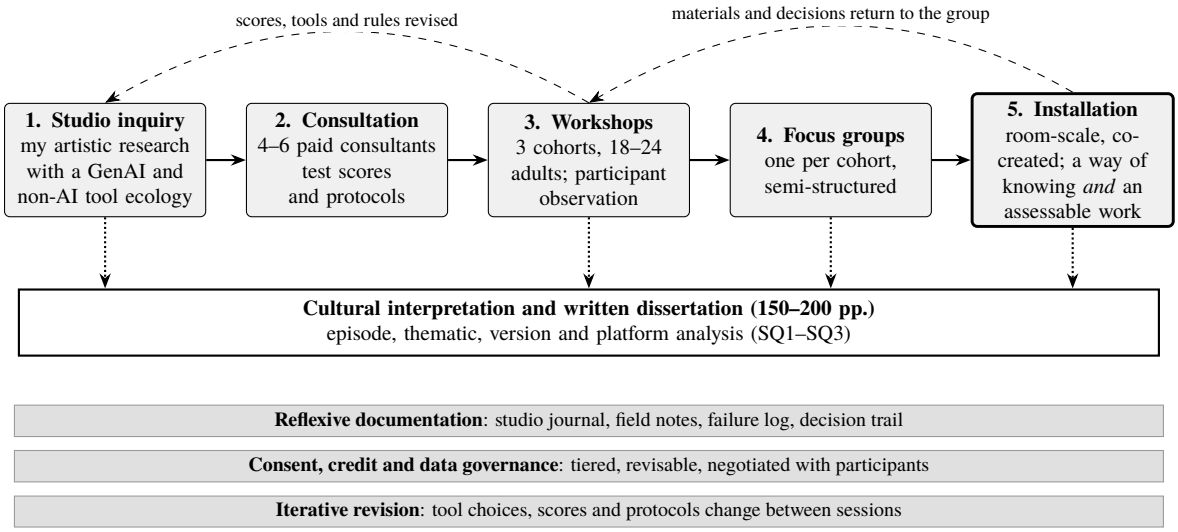


Figure 1: Proposed research-creation design (planned, not yet conducted). Solid arrows show the sequence of phases, dashed arrows feedback that revises earlier decisions, and dotted arrows evidence moving into interpretation. The grey bands run across every phase.

7 Analysis

Analysis is aligned with the subquestions. For SQ1, I will analyze selected workshop episodes multimodally, adapting the video microethnography McArthur (2015) used for interface interaction, and read interfaces, terms of service and model documentation as cultural documents. For SQ2, reflexive thematic analysis of the focus groups (Braun and Clarke, 2019) is read alongside episodes and group-authored rules. For SQ3, version analysis charts each state of the artwork against the contributors who shaped it, after the version timelines of Hodson (2019, 10), together with the studio journal and failure archive. Episode selection includes routine uptake, refusal, conflict, misrecognition and unexpected invention. These materials are put in dialogue rather than triangulated into one objective account, with attention to discrepant cases, reflexive memos and a transparent decision trail. The design cannot isolate "the effect of AI" from facilitation, platform, group history and institution, and tools will change during the study, so claims will be situated and analytically transferable, not causal.

8 Ethics, governance and accessibility

Consent will be tiered and revisable (Strengers et al., 2021), given separately for recording, model input, research analysis, exhibition, documentation and reuse. Anyone may refuse GenAI or any output and remain an equal creative participant, because every activity has a manual route. No identifiable voice, image or text, and no culturally sensitive material, will be sent to a model without specific consent. Commercial services may retain or reuse prompts and outputs under their terms; participants will be told this, and I will prefer local or institutionally approved tools and review choices at ethics approval. Groups will agree in advance how withdrawal works once material has been remixed: identifiable contributions are removed where feasible,

but exhibited composite work may not be fully separable. Legal ownership, platform terms, public credit, felt authorship and research authorship are treated as distinct. Data will be minimized, stored securely with restricted access, and retained and deleted on a stated schedule. Participants and consultants will receive honoraria and access costs; if funding falls short, I will reduce the sample or the number of sessions rather than rely on unpaid artistic labour. I will support visual, sonic, physical, linguistic and technical participation, with alternatives to sound-only or vision-only interaction and help at every level of AI literacy, and participants will not be asked to perform trauma or educate me about misrecognition. Participation alone does not make the process equitable (Birhane et al., 2022).

9 Access and case-study architecture

Three problems of access are foreseeable. *Participants:* recruitment depends on open calls; if a cohort cannot finish, its completed sessions remain usable as a smaller case. *Venue:* the gallery is a proposal; if it is unavailable, the work will be shown in another campus space or as a documented installation. *Tools:* platforms may close, change terms or prices, or update models, so Phase 1 keeps substitutes, including a local model, and records versions.

Expandable case-study architecture. The core doctoral study is self-contained. After the initial studio inquiry, the project is designed to accommodate one bounded case-study strand developed with Dr. Caines. Her SSHRC project *Interfacing, Playtesting, Resetting* (Goodfellow Craig, 2026) is a possible point of connection, because both inquiries concern improvisation, playtesting and how creative technologies organize participation. Such a strand could take one of three forms: a comparative analysis of authorized project materials; an embedded creative workshop or playtesting context; or a public research-creation or exhibition context. It would extend, not replace, the core research questions, and would require separate agreement on roles, access, community or partner governance, consent, data, ethics, resources, credit and outputs. The exact relationship, if any, would be determined with Dr. Caines and relevant partners. The doctoral study does not depend on that connection.

10 Contributions

Without presuming its findings, the study aims to contribute a conceptual account of how GenAI mediation redistributes interpretive authority, recognition and responsibility in collective art-making; situated empirical evidence of how collaborators negotiate transformations, defaults, refusals and credit; a research-creation method combining studio inquiry, participant observation, focus groups, episode and version analysis and public co-creation; a collaborative installation and scores that keep these negotiations perceptible; and situated principles for consent, refusal, attribution, accessibility, platform choice and shared governance rather than universal rules. Its originality lies not in new software but in following the same contributions across studio, workshop, focus group and exhibition.

11 Program and supervisor fit

The project belongs to Technology in Practice because it examines critically how GenAI platforms, interfaces and institutions configure cultural practice, and to Media & Culture because it studies cultural production, representation, participation, authorship and labour. It answers the program's aim of "promoting the application of critical theory and research" (Joint Graduate Program in Communication & Culture, 2026a) and its PhD objectives, which name "creative exhibitions" among the routes to independent research (Joint Graduate Program in Communication & Culture, 2026b). Dr. Caines's work on critical improvisation, socially responsive creative technologies and GenAI is its closest ground; her GenAI study focused mostly on course and workshop design (Caines, 2026, 176), whereas this project follows how collaborators negotiate one another's contributions in sustained art-making and public exhibition.

12 Provisional chapters and timeline

Chapters. (1) GenAI and cultural participation; (2) participation, mediation and collective production; (3) methodology: research-creation, studio, workshops and reflexivity; (4) the studio inquiry and the tool ecology as cultural document; (5) translation, recognition and refusal in the workshops; (6) credit, responsibility and the public artwork; (7) protocols and wider stakes.

Year 1 (2027–28)	Courses; literature review; Phase 1 studio inquiry begins.
Year 2 (2028–29)	Comprehensive examinations; formal proposal and ethics approval (Joint Graduate Program in Communication & Culture, 2016); Phase 2 pilots.
Year 3 (2029–30)	Phase 3 workshops with three cohorts; Phase 4 focus groups; analysis.
Year 4 (2030–31)	Phase 5 co-creation and proposed exhibition; writing and defence. Year 5 in reserve.

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